

1.3 Some Questions The World Is Asking

Will cost drive companies to go the open source and free software way? If they do, will they have to sacrifice on functionality or assured tech support?

Is the might of commercial software giants too much for open source to stand up to? Is the collective knowledge pool a formidable threat to conventional software makers?

Just how compatible will an open source system be with existing systems?

How long before open source (especially Linux) manages to shake off the hacker-geek kid image amongst corporates?

Is open source an idea that sounds all nice but may not stand firm in the gale of commercialisation blowing in?

All this, time alone will tell. But we can't help feeling that for the sake of innovation, for the sake of technology sharing (which some say is what a civilised world should adopt), and for the sake of cost cutting, open source must live.

1.4 What Is Linux?

You'd probably say, "Linux is an operating system." Yes, but remember, however, that the strictest definition of Linux is only the *kernel*. The more relaxed definition would be an overall package called a *distribution* that is ready to install and use. There are well over 300 distributions of Linux, most of them containing commonly-needed applications—and even games!

Linux was originally meant to be a UNIX clone. Here, by "clone," we mean that it would look and behave *like* UNIX. But bear in mind that Linux does not contain a single line of UNIX code! The source code of the two is entirely different.